they could expect to find administrative jobs with shorter hours and higher pay.

Within families, inter-caste marriages were very much frowned upon, as higher castes took a great deal of pride in their station. When castes did mix, dining etiquette—from table arrangements to the type of food served—became quite tricky. For as many ways as there are to divide a population based on economic and ancestral status, each of them seems to have manifested itself in the practice of cooking, sharing, and eating food. The different types of food preparation are themselves judged as either “pukka” (perfect) or “kacca” (undressed), and only the former type is appropriate to share with others.

Specifically, kacca foods are simply boiled, steamed, or stewed dishes; served without any type of fat, they are acceptable as part of family meals or to give to servants. Pukka foods have been deep-fried in clarified butter, or “ghee,” which means they are protected from outside impurities, according to Hindu tradition. The historical writer Margaret Visser says, “When a Brahmin gives a feast and wants as many people as possible to come, he chooses a menu of *pukka* food and cooks it himself, for his touch can pollute nobody.”

Though castes are not outwardly obvious in terms of skin color or clothing, many Indian surnames denote the hierarchy of his or her family. It is one of the few oppressive regimes in the world in which the people who are revered and the people who are impoverished are genetically one and the same.